

Which of the former cities comprising the current New York City are most similar?

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1. Introduction

1.1 Background

One idea suggested by the instructor, is to compare two cities and see how similar or dissimilar they are. In the previous exercise, neighborhoods in Manhattan were examined. However, New York City has five boroughs, corresponding to the five counties within New York City. The five boroughs of New York City were each themselves their own city at one time. Five cities came together to form what is now New York City. The five boroughs are Bronx, Brooklyn, Manhattan, Queens, and Staten Island. Respectively these are each a county: Bronx County, Kings County, New York County, Queens County, and Richmond county. Many cities are within a county, rather than comprising of counties. The boroughs of New York City can be treated as cities for the purposes of the suggested question of examining how similar or dissimilar cities can be.

1.2 Problem

Each borough has its own characteristics and reputation. At the same time, New York City is a dynamic place. As the boroughs change, their characteristics and therefore their similarities and dissimilarities also change. Heuristics used even by New Yorkers to group the boroughs may be misconceived or out of date at any given time. Which of the boroughs of New York City, former cities in their own right, are most similar.

1.3 Interest

There are many possible applications of knowing which boroughs are most similar. One case might be New Yorkers happy with their current location, yet believing they will have to move soon. Knowing which boroughs are similar or dissimilar to the one they live in and like (or dislike) can help guide them in choosing which other locations to examine as a possible new residence. In addition, real estate brokers armed with data showing these similarities/dissimilarities might be more able to persuade clients to consider looking at areas they might not otherwise consider. Recently residents of two boroughs believed their neighborhood characteristics might change drastically, and many considered moving or in some cases moved. Neighborhoods of Brooklyn were faced with the L train subway shutting down for an extended period of time. Neighborhoods in Queens were faced with the prospect of Amazon establishing a head quarters there, and it was believed rents would climb drastically, and that the already crowded subways would become much more crowded. (At the last minute the L train had its repair plan changed to allow at least limited train service to continue, and Amazon backed out of establishing a headquarters in Queens.) Brooklyn and Queens are geographically contiguous and are often lumped together as “outer boroughs”, i.e. not Manhattan, but are they similar, or are other noncontiguous boroughs, even counter intuitively Manhattan, more similar?

